StoryCast
Research and Documentation

Figma wireframes: click here
Figma high-fidelity mockups: click here

1. Project overview

StoryCast is a three-page accessible microsite for audio and video storytelling. It shows short stories from real voices and makes them easy to find, watch, listen to, and read. The site is built with plain HTML, Sass compiled to CSS, and a small amount of vanilla JavaScript. It uses no frameworks.

Page	Purpose
Home	which introduces StoryCast, features one story, highlights this week's listening selection, and lists all the others with category filters.
Story page	which gives one story its own page with the media player, a full transcript, an accessibility and credits sidebar, and related stories. Four story pages share this template (share-excel-workbook, wise-owl, tedx-talk, google-drive-access).
About	which explains the mission, the independent editorial approach, the six accessibility commitments, the three-step engagement model, and a contribution call-to-action.

2. Research

I used desk research instead of surveys or interviews. I looked at three kinds of sources:

- **Reference sites.** StoryCorps (short animated stories), LibriVox (audiobooks read by volunteers) and a first draft of the concept built with an AI design tool. I looked at how they organise stories, label media and present transcripts.

- **Accessibility guidance.** I used the WCAG 2.1 AA success criteria as the standard, especially colour contrast, keyboard access, visible focus, captions and transcripts for time-based media, and heading structure.
- **Media sources and licences.** I checked where stories, audio and video could come from legally: YouTube's embedded player, LibriVox (public domain in the USA) and Pixabay (Pixabay Content License).

What I learned

- People who cannot hear or see the media still need the story, so every story needs a text version next to it.
- A story site works best when visitors can choose by category and search instead of scrolling through a long list.
- Playing media should always be the visitor's choice. Nothing should start by itself.
- Sound-only stories need a written transcript, because browsers do not show captions for audio-only players.

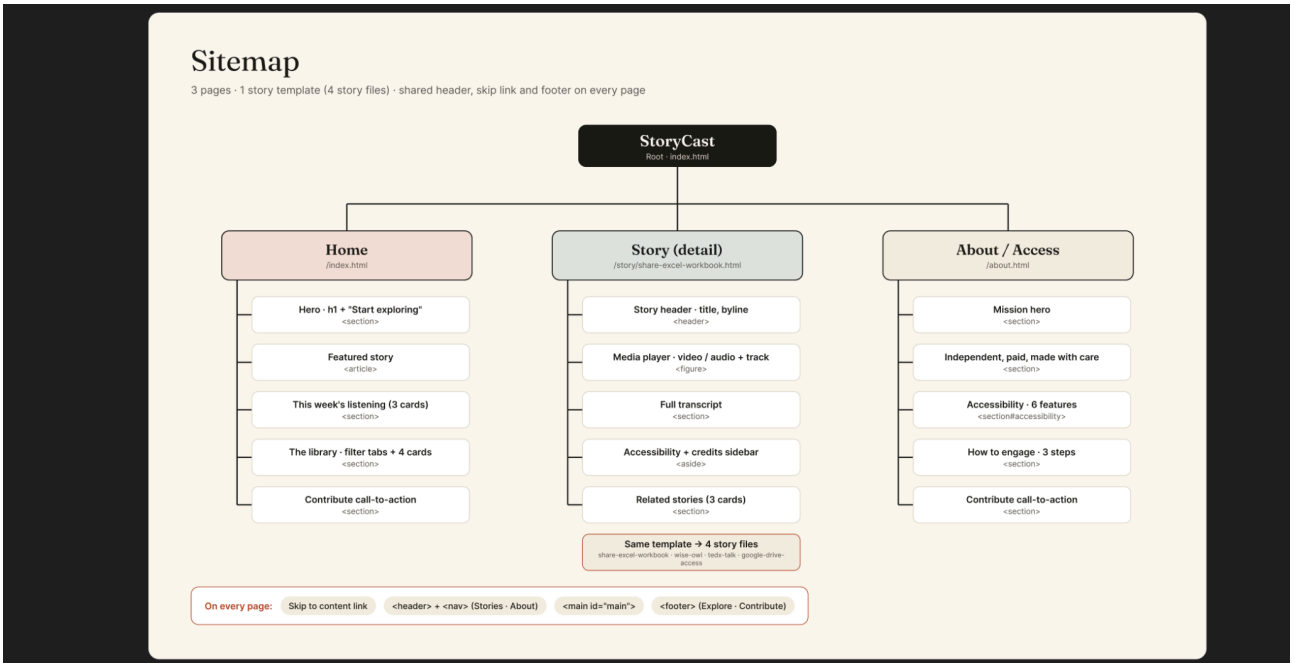
Assumed users

These are design assumptions, not interview results.

- A curious visitor who wants a short, moving story on a phone during a break.
- A deaf or hard-of-hearing visitor who needs captions and transcripts.
- A blind or low-vision visitor who uses a screen reader, keyboard or zoom and needs good structure and alt text.
- A student or teacher who wants to find stories by theme and read them closely.

3. Information architecture

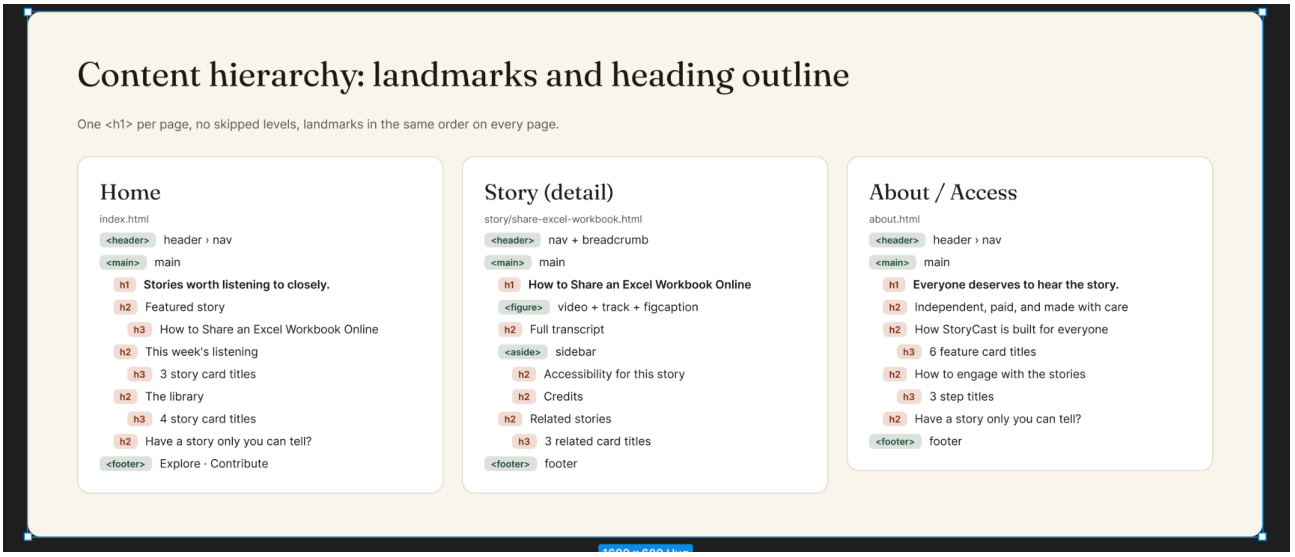
Sitemap



Sitemap: Home links to every story. Each story page links to two related stories and back to Discover.

Every page carries the same header (brand, "Discover" and "About StoryCast") and the same footer links. Every story page links back to Discover and offers two related stories.

Hierarchy of each page



Page hierarchy for Home, Story detail and About / Access.

Page	Order of content
Home	Page intro with the main heading, featured story, "Find your next story" with search and category filters, the story grid, and a closing note that links to About
Story page	Back link, category label, title, details (creator, format, length), media player, description, transcript, and "Stay a little longer" with two related stories
About	Intro, cover photo, then four sections: mission, editorial principles, access commitments and contact

Navigation and labels

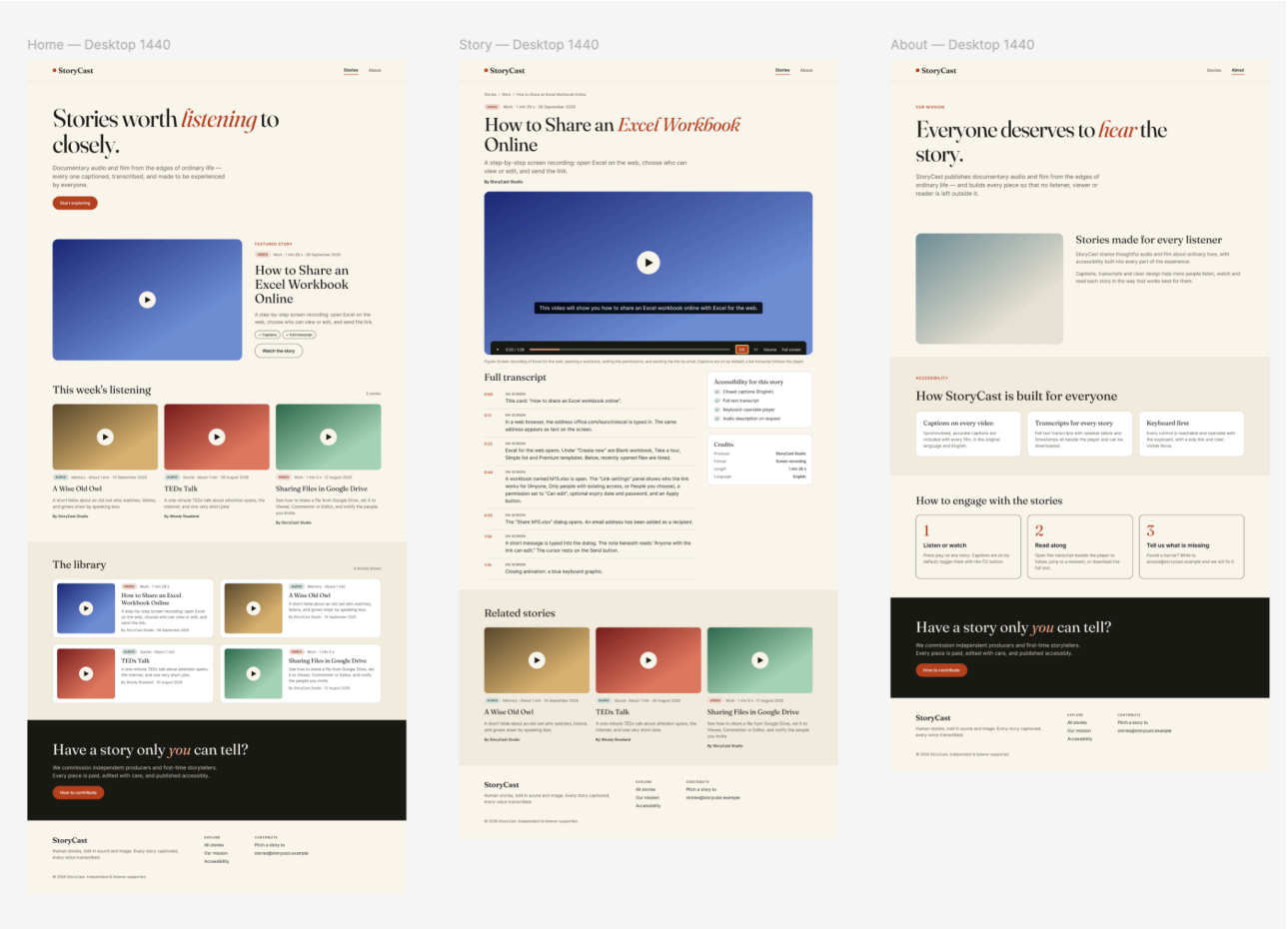
Navigation has two clear destinations, because the site is small. Category names (Culture, People, Nature) are plain words. Link text says where it goes, such as "Back to Discover" and "The story behind StoryCast". A visitor can reach any story in two clicks from any page.

Content types

- Five stories are YouTube videos with captions.
- One story is an audio recording of a poem, read by a LibriVox volunteer.
- One story is a short silent video with a written visual description.

4. Design process and decisions

Wireframes and mockups. I planned the layouts as wireframes first in Figma, then built high-fidelity mockups for Home, Story and About, plus a mobile Home. The Figma file also holds the sitemap, the page hierarchy and the design tokens.



Design tokens. Colours, type and spacing are defined once and reused everywhere.

Token	Choice
Colours	A warm off-white background, deep dark text, accessible accent/link colors, soft green/neutral tags for category filter tabs, and dark contrasting background tones for footer and player areas.
Typography	DM Serif Display (or equivalent serif heading style) for clear hierarchy and DM Sans for clean body text readability.
Spacing and shape	A modular spacing scale, coupled with consistent corner radii (4px, 6px, 8px) across cards and container sections.

Layout. I used CSS Grid for card layouts (such as the 3-card weekly listening and 4-card library grids) and About section grids, while relying on Flexbox for navigation headers, filter tab bars, and internal card layouts.

Container query. The story card acts as the primary modular responsive component. When rendered inside wider layout containers, the card adapts into a side-by-side media and metadata layout; inside narrower containers or sidebars, it stacks vertically.

5. Technical implementation

- **Semantic HTML.** Each page uses header, nav, main, article, section, aside, figure, figcaption, details and footer. Each page has one h1, and heading levels do not skip.
- **Sass architecture.** Three token partials (_colors, _typography, _spacing), a tokens file that turns them into CSS custom properties, reset, base, layout and utility partials, and one partial for each component. main.scss imports all of them and compiles to css/main.css.
- **BEM naming.** Class names follow block__element--modifier, such as card__title and site-nav__link.
- **Cascade layers.** Declared once, in the order reset, tokens, base, layout, components, utilities. Every partial puts its rules in its layer, so layer order decides conflicts instead of specificity.
- **JavaScript.** One small file adds category filtering and live search on Home, and highlights the line being read on the audio story page. The site works without it.
- **Media.** The poem uses a native audio element with a track caption file. The silent clip uses a native video element with a track caption file. The five YouTube stories use YouTube's embedded player, with captions on by default.

6. Accessibility

The site is designed toward WCAG 2.1 AA. The main measures are:

Area	What was done
Colour contrast	Contrast ratios for body text and interactive controls exceed standard requirements (minimum 4.5:1 for body text, 3:1 for large text and UI components).
Keyboard use	Every interactive element is a native focusable HTML element (<a>, <button>, <input>). The first tab stop on every page is a <a href="#main"> "Skip to content" link.
Visible focus	Distinct 3px focus outlines are applied across all focusable elements without relying on default browser hides.
Captions and transcripts	Each detail page includes a dedicated <section> for the full transcript directly following the media player <figure>.
Text alternatives	All visual content includes concise visual alternative text (alt=""), while decorative elements carry aria-hidden="true".
ARIA, only where needed	Used only where semantic HTML is insufficient (e.g., aria-pressed="true/false" for library filter buttons, aria-current="page" on navigation items).
Media behaviour	Nothing plays automatically. Players are keyboard operable and YouTube frames have descriptive titles
Motion	: Animations and transitions respect prefers-reduced-motion: reduce.

7. Testing

- **Keyboard:** I tabbed through every page and could reach everything, and the focus ring was always visible.
- **Responsive:** I checked the pages at 320, 600, 768 and 1280 pixels and at 200% zoom.
- **Container query:** the card switched to the side-by-side layout at the 480 pixel container width.

8. Credits and licences

- **Media content:** Story media clips sourced from open libraries under Public Domain / Creative Commons / Pixabay Content Licenses.
- **Fonts:** Google Fonts (DM Serif Display, DM Sans).